

WHAT IS MOONLIGHTING?



Dictionaries define it as working at an extra job, especially without telling your main employer



But employers may differ. For some, it may only involve projects/employment done for a competitor, while others may look at even unrelated but income-generating passion projects, which take away from office hours, as moonlighting



The trend, experts say, intensified during the pandemic because of remote working



No law prohibits dual employment in India other than the Factories Act. In many cases, the IT sector is exempt from it

WHY THE IT INDUSTRY?

THE \$150-BILLION-PLUS SOFTWARE EXPORTS INDUSTRY EMPLOYS 4.5 MILLION PEOPLE—ONE OF THE LARGEST EMPLOYERS OF THE COUNTRY'S WHITE-COLLAR WORKFORCE

WHICH OTHER SECTORS?

► Almost every knowledge- and services-based industry has it going on in some degree. Freelancing portals brim with listings for creative work such as design, writing and translation. Even non-creative service-based roles such as HR, finance, sales and marketing, and legal skills are on demand on these sites. The education sector is especially prone to it

► Roles that do not require the employee's physical presence throughout the day—such as sales executives, retail employees, social media marketers and UI/UX/auto designers—are more likely to lend themselves to moonlighting

lighting as “the act of working at an extra job, especially without telling your main employer”. What do others think? To gauge the popular opinion on moonlighting, *BT* undertook a social media poll of 5,500 respondents. It found that more than 44 per cent of those surveyed don't view moonlighting as cheating (*see chart*).

Of course, moonlighting is not to be confused with gig work, or freelancing, which comprises outcome-based assignments without being attached to any one full-time employer. Moonlighting falls into two buckets. One, taking up income-generating side jobs in the same industry as the primary job. Two, taking up income-generating hobby projects unrelated to the primary job. While the former is the subject of fiercest censure by IT industry captains, the latter is not without complications either. And the dividing line between what is acceptable and what is not, is a thin one.

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PREMJI, FOR INSTANCE, clarified at an event later that the definition of moonlighting for him was “having a second job secretly”. Vouching for transparency, he said that employees can have candid conversations with the organisation about wanting to play in a band at night or taking up a project over the weekend and see if that works for the employer or not. Says Yeshab Giri, Chief Commercial Officer, Staffing & Randstad Technologies at recruitment and staffing firm Randstad India: “As long as it doesn't impact the core job or productivity or stickiness to the organisation, but is just the pursuing of a passion which has a monetary impact, it doesn't qualify as moonlighting. But it's a thin line.”

Still, the employer may seek disclosure, adds Sanju Ballurkar, President at Experis IT, a subsidiary of staffing firm ManpowerGroup. “If you are generating serious remuneration from it and it takes up a majority of your time on the weekend, you should have very good reason why you don't want to disclose it.” So, the point of contention may arise from the division of time, attention, effort, loyalty or resources. Dwindling engagement is not something organisations investing heavily to attract, train and retain talent may take kindly to, especially when the Great Resignation has driven up attrition to an average 20 per cent-plus across industries.

But the deepest concern surrounding the trend is more about the misuse of confidential data and the breach of contracts IT services firms have with their